February 23, 2021

Hon. Esther Furman

Westchester Family Court

CC: Jennifer Jackman, Tara Walsh, Max DiFabio, Jason Advocate, Stephen Russell

Re: Tara Walsh v. Stephen Russell

Hon. Judge Furman,

My name is Kelly Turnure and I am Steve Russell's partner. I feel it necessary that I contact you both to correct some misunderstandings about our life together and protect myself and Steve's daughter, E.V. Recent rulings regarding interim support have led to direct harm that you should be aware of before a final ruling so we can come to a healthy and safe equilibrium going forward.

Our life is very different from the picture that's been painted in your courtroom. Regardless of what you may have heard we do not have an extravagant lifestyle. We share a Ford. We recently bought a pop-up camper because we like to be outdoors and drive to new places. I've never flown in a private jet, nor do I expect to. It's a lovely life, even in these difficult times. But, it is not what Ms. Walsh describes.

I put myself through college as a waitress in San Francisco before landing a role at an investment bank. I've worked in banking and investment management - and took an opportunity to move to East Africa to work on a project I found interesting and important. Until Steve and I lived together I had an adorable yet modest rent-controlled apartment that allowed me the flexibility to focus on other interests.

Steve grew up in Detroit. His mom was a nurse and his Dad sold roof-coating. They went bankrupt sending him and his brother to Stanford. Though Steve has had some influence in Silicon Valley, it has not been as a money-maker. For those who know him, he is more of an inventor and coach who lacks the money-centeredness that builds the fortunes like that of the Walshes or a Trump. His reputation as someone not to be trifled with stems not from raw power or wealth, but because he has a knack for seeing what other people don't and is a truly decent man.

Steve may be known for his investment in Uber at the court, but you should know that investment was a mere $20 and Ms. Walsh has no idea of Steve's commitments and liabilities. We learned during civil discovery that Ms. Walsh secretly stole pictures of Steve's hidden and private financial documents and sent them to her boyfriend. She didn't understand what she was looking at and her estimates could not be more off-base. In fact, one of the documents submitted for this hearing was stolen. Ironically, rather than showing that Steve is independently wealthy - it shows that he sold his shares for a pittance during the time that Tara insisted on flying in a private jet - for infant Evie of course - and living in a luxurious home - again for Evie. It was the first time Steve was forced to choose between making a terrible financial decision and seeing his daughter, unfortunately it has become the status quo.

Public copy: the child's legal name is shown as E.V. Otherwise unchanged.

The shocking truth Judge Furman is that you are the only Westchester Judge in two and a half years to even proceed with a hearing in this matter. I am writing because this is not a normal case and Ms. Walsh is not some poor woman running from a bad relationship. Her enabled behavior has direct consequences for not just Steve, but all those close to him, and most importantly—his daughter Evie. The damage caused by her single-minded focus on maximizing her own assets at Steve's expense is devastating. I understand this hearing is about Evie, not Tara's choices - but in this case they are intertwined.

The life Ms. Walsh testified to having with Steve was manufactured for this specific moment. They had always lived on separate coasts, but Ms. Walsh chose to move to San Francisco with Steve after Evie was born for the sole purpose of manipulating him into marriage - then divorcing him for money. She texted her friend her plan just a few days before moving:

> ***"WELL HE IS GOING TO BUY A $2.3 MILLION DOLLAR APARTMENT IN SF AND PUT IT IN A TRUST UNDER EVIE'S NAME I CAN CONTROL. IF I SUE HIM FOR CHILD SUPPORT I WILL GET LIKE $2K A MONTH. WHICH IS NOT ENOUGH TO LIVE OFF OF. I'M BETTER PRETENDING I WANT TO BE WITH HIM AND GETTING THE MOST WHILE I CAN - THEN LEAVING HIM FOR GOOD."***
>
> ***"I THINK HE WILL ALSO MARRY ME... THEN I CAN JUST DIVORCE HIM I REALLY MOSTLY HATE HIM AT THIS POINT - NOT SURE I CAN MANAGE TO HOLD MYSELF BACK."***[1]

Ms. Walsh did attempt to manipulate Steve into marrying her for money the entire time she was in San Francisco - often using their daughter as leverage. These texts were sent two weeks before she fled San Francisco:

> ***"YOU JUST DON'T GET IT, IF YOU DID I WOULDN'T NEED TO BEG YOU TO MARRY ME LIKE A PATHETIC PERSON. I WANT TO MARRY YOU BC OF HER - BC I WANT TO GIVE HER THE BEST SHOT AT LIFE. BC LOVING EACH OTHER WITH BRING HER HAPPINESS."***
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> ***"MOSTLY YOUR JUST LETTING DOWN EVIE - SHE DESERVED A FATHER WHO LOVED HER MOTHER - SHE DESERVED A SOLID MAN WHO DIDN'T GIVE UP. YOUR MESSING HER UP FOR THE REST OF HER LIFE BC YOU THINK YOU DESERVE BETTER." (MAY 15, 2018)***

When that didn't work she faked a pregnancy. While trying to solicit a proposal she texted Steve, *"I'm also probably depressed because I'm pregnant,"* and then two days later she texted her friend, *"I think he knows I'm not* ***actually*** *pregnant."*

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[1] The text messages referenced here were produced in discovery by Tara in the San Francisco civil matter. True and correct copies can be made available to the Court upon request. In fact, every statement in this letter has supporting evidence available to the court upon request.

Within two weeks Ms. Walsh had been diagnosed with Borderline Personality Disorder and was caught surreptitiously 'slipping' her antipsychotic medication, into Steve's drink by the nanny, amongst other crimes. Toxicology tests and clinical observation suggest she drugged him with Lithium and Psychedelics as well. Ms. Walsh has admitted in open court to drugging Steve with Seroquel and Steve was granted a permanent restraining order against her in San Francisco after a long form hearing over the facts.

But like I said, this isn't about Steve or Ms. Walsh. Ms. Walsh currently has custody and Evie needs to be provided for. Fortunately she is. Ms. Walsh fled with Evie in violation of the San Francisco Restraining Order to her family's compound in Chappaqua after the San Francisco Court granted Steve custody and supervised visitation between Evie and Ms. Walsh based on her drugging of Steve. Since that time Ms. Walsh and Evie have lived on an extravagant compound in Chappaqua with all of their needs taken care of. The main house sits at the end of a quarter-mile private drive. Tara's sister, Brienne, described it in her blog:

> *"My parents live in a house that was built in 1781. It's name is Tara Knoll. When they bought it, my dad was a prince of Wall Street... It's set on 7 acres of land, and it's surrounded by a 100 acre nature preserve. It has a guest house, a pool house, a play house, and a shed."*

> *"In a house that size, you don't need to share a room with anyone. The room that was mine there is roughly the size of our apartment. The closet has a walk-in closet."*

The property is staffed and Maura Walsh, Evie's grandmother and stay-at-home mom, watches Evie day-to-day. Ms. Walsh's sister also provides care. The Chappaqua mansion oozes with a kind of privilege one hears of, but seldom gets to see. Tara does not live there due to financial constraints, but rather because the court confined her to her parents home out of concern for her mental health.

You can imagine our surprise when Ms. Walsh claimed that her mother started charging $25/hour to watch Evie after assuring the custody court that Evie would be safe with them while Tara focused on her mental health. Maura Walsh has denied these childcare charges to us, but ignored a subpoena to avoid testifying against her daughter. Although one couldn't tell from this courtroom, I've been present for phone calls between Steve and Mr. Walsh where he describes himself and his wife as Evie's caregivers and that she is well taken care of. I believe these interactions, combined with the fact that Ms. Walsh no longer requests reimbursement for 'Maura Walsh's charges' speaks for itself.

Please understand that Tara was CEO of a Marketing Agency in Manhattan and made nearly $250,000 per year when she became pregnant with Evie. The reason she is not doing that now is because her family insists on her continuing to live at their home, or apparently not leave Westchester—Tara's family threatened to take custody if she did move away.

Because ALL of Ms. Walsh and Evie's needs are taken care of on their compound, she uses the money that you mandate to bribe witnesses and to directly harass us in a series of escalating schemes. For example, two months after she testified to you that she was living in a cold and cramped attic and couldn't afford a dresser for Evie - she bought her friend a $1,000+ dress for her birthday.[2] This is the same friend who witnessed part of Tara's crime and has ignored multiple subpoenas in the case.

I was harassed and physically harmed on my trip to NY as well, and unlike Steve, I cannot get a restraining order. On a snowy day before court the air was deliberately let out of our tire which could have easily caused an accident on icy roads. There was also a 'bug bomb' left off in our apartment that left me with a rash that sent me to the doctor. Each of these incidents occurred while we were present in New York for court in this matter. Although Tara likely did not personally carry this out herself, the pattern of harassing behavior at Tara'a direction should not be enabled by the Court.

So what does Ms. Walsh want across hundreds of settlement negotiations? For Steve to financially support her—while she continues to block Steve's relationship with Evie. Before Evie was born Steve continuously tried to, "write up a positive vision for our coparenting situation," and "to have a meeting of the minds on the broad strokes of how we are going to bring our daughter into the world and raise her." Ms. Walsh would refuse to talk about anything other than the financial portion.

Ms. Walsh recently proposed a settlement where Steve would buy Evie a home and pay support in excess of $150k / year. In return he could visit Ms. Walsh and Evie at their new home. Last night she sent an email to Steve's attorney saying, "he continues to have the option of stepping up like a man to do the right thing. And by the right thing ***I mean providing financial support for her. At this point that's all she needs from him.***" To think that a three-year old girl only needs 'financial support' from a good Father who loves her and wants to spend time with her, is frankly detached from reality. It is not what is best for Evie, it is what is best for Ms. Walsh. Ms. Walsh is convinced it is only a matter of time before she loses custody and if things continue the way they are, she will. ***If Ms. Walsh losing custody also means losing a lifestyle supported by Evie's child support, I shudder to think what she would do***.

In Tara'a mind, the incentives to keep Steve and Evie apart are already great - providing a financial incentive will only give Ms Walsh more reason to separate the two. Already she is going to extreme and even criminal lengths to keep them apart. At the last visit the court-appointed supervisor, specifically picked by the judge for this case, described the harassment they experienced at the drop-off as having caused, 'the worst sheer fright of [her] life.' The time before that she accused Steve of having given Evie suspicious bruises before she knew that Steve, the nanny, and supervisor had noticed the bruises at the top of the visit. Either Ms. Walsh tried to cast benign bruises as Steve being abusive - or she intentionally hurt Evie to blame it on Steve. Part of the reason we haven't been to NY in so long is we are waiting for some protection for the court.

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[2] 'Thank you' instagram post by Rashmi Narendra June 17, 2019. True and correct copies can be made available to the Court upon request.

But that is outside of your jurisdiction. You decide on support. ***Tara knew when she was pregnant with Evie that according to NY law she would receive around $2,000 in child support. She engaged in multiple campaigns of disinformation, abuse, and more - spanning the course of years - in an attempt to muddy the waters and obtain the life she believes she deserves.*** Tara has a desired annual budget of $250,000 and declares an annual income of $48,000. She was approved for a mortgage of $550k+ with monthly payments equal to her declared income. She claims that three year old Evie is responsible for over 70% of their household expenses.

There has yet to be a custody hearing on 2.5 years. What happens when/if Ms. Walsh loses custody of Evie? She would lose the financial life she desires - unless she continued to live with her parents. I don't want to contemplate the lengths she would go to prevent that. In this instance Evie will still be well taken care of with a standard amount of child support - and keeps Evie from being her mother's path toward a wealthier life.

In the last month our bank account was frozen over false claims Steve was in arrears, Ms. Walsh has threatened to have him arrested for failure to pay, called an emergency hearing over the matter, and was caught falsifying childcare payments to her mother.

Right now Evie has no expenses and has everything financially a little girl could want. Evie has a father who would give every last penny to help his daughter, but letting his daughter be used as a pawn for financial gain is unacceptable. She deserves better. Please don't ask him to keep trading Evie's future adventures for Ms. Walsh's housekeeper, gardner, and $1,000 per month shoe budget. Hopefully with a clear boundary and ruling we can move forward with other conversations.

Thank you for your time.

Sincerely,

Kelly Turnure